

V4 Leadership Vulnerability Archetypes

Pillar	Vulnerability	Difficulty	Level 2
Time Required	45-55 minutes	Group Size	3-8 leaders (optimal: 5-6)
Mode	Leader (requires participants in management/leadership roles)	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	None (this is a self-awareness exercise, not a team exercise)	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Leaders avoiding vulnerability, team trust scores low under specific managers, disconnect between leader self-perception and team feedback

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Leaders set the neurochemical tone for their teams. A leader's behaviour acts as a social signal that the brains of their team members constantly process. When a leader models openness, team members' brains release oxytocin (trust) and reduce cortisol (threat). When a leader models guardedness, team members' amygdalae mirror that defensiveness.

Most leaders have a default pattern for handling vulnerability that they developed early in their career and have never examined. This exercise makes that pattern visible. Self-awareness activates the prefrontal cortex (the brain's executive control centre), which allows leaders to make deliberate choices about their behaviour rather than operating on autopilot.

The archetype framework gives leaders a non-threatening way to examine their default pattern. It is easier to say "I tend toward the Stoic Strategist" than to say "I have difficulty showing emotion at work."

Before You Begin

PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY CHECK

This exercise is for leaders only, run in a peer group of leaders (not with their direct reports present). Running this with direct reports would create performance anxiety and performative behaviour.

If only one leader is available, this can be run as a 1:1 coaching exercise with the manager's manager or an external coach.

The Exercise

Phase 1: Introduce the Archetypes (10 minutes)

Present four leadership vulnerability archetypes. Emphasise that these are not personality types. They are default patterns that can change. Most leaders are a blend of two.

Archetype	Default Pattern	Strength	Vulnerability Blind Spot
The Stoic Strategist	Data-driven, logical, composed under pressure. Rarely shows emotion.	Stability. Teams know they can rely on this leader not to panic.	Team cannot read them. Emotional distance creates a trust gap. People stop sharing problems because they assume the leader does not care.
The Visionary Charmer	Inspiring, energetic, big-picture thinker. Light on detail follow-through.	Motivation. People feel excited about the direction.	Avoids sharing uncertainty or doubt. When things go wrong, the shift from optimism to reality feels like a betrayal to the team.
The Shield Bearer	Protects the team from organisational pressure. Absorbs conflict and stress upward.	Loyalty. Teams feel safe because this leader takes the hits.	Never lets the team see what they are dealing with. This creates an artificial bubble that eventually bursts. Team is unprepared when reality arrives.
The Perfectionist	High standards, detail-oriented, leads by example. Rarely delegates fully.	Quality. Work output is consistently strong.	Admitting mistakes or uncertainty feels like personal failure. This creates pressure for the team to also be perfect, which kills risk-taking and innovation.

Phase 2: Self-Identification (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Read through the four archetypes. Think about which one sounds most like you at your default setting, particularly under pressure. Most of us are a blend of two. Write down your primary and secondary archetype, and one specific situation where your default pattern helped you and one where it got in the way."

Give 10 minutes for private reflection and writing. This is not a quick gut reaction exercise. Leaders need time to think honestly about their patterns.

Phase 3: Sharing and Discussion (15-20 minutes)

Each leader shares their primary archetype, one strength example, and one blind spot example. Facilitation approach:

- After each share, ask: "What does your team see that you might not?" This question invites the leader to consider the gap between intention and impact.
- Allow other leaders to offer perspective: "I'm also a Stoic Strategist. Here's what I've learned my team reads into my silence..."
- Do NOT let this become a peer coaching session. Keep it at the awareness level.

Phase 4: The Vulnerability Gap Question (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Now the harder question. Given your archetype, what is the one thing your team would most benefit from seeing you do differently? Not a personality change. One specific behaviour."

Examples: The Stoic Strategist might say "I could let my team see when I'm uncertain about a decision instead of presenting everything as resolved." The Shield Bearer might say "I could share more about the organisational pressures we're navigating instead of absorbing them silently."

Each leader writes down their one behaviour change and shares it with the group. This creates a peer accountability mechanism.

Phase 5: Close (5 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Your archetype is not a label. It's a starting point for self-awareness. The goal is not to stop being who you are. The goal is to recognise when your default pattern is helping your team and when it's creating distance. One behaviour change. Try it in the next two weeks and we'll check in."

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
A leader insists none of the archetypes fit them	"That's possible. Use them as a starting point and describe your own pattern in your own words. What's your default when things get difficult?" The archetypes are a scaffold, not a diagnosis.
A leader identifies their archetype but minimises the blind spot	Ask: "If I asked your team the same question, would they agree with your assessment of the blind spot?" This gentle challenge invites

	honest self-reflection without confrontation.
The discussion becomes competitive ("I'm a blend of all four")	Redirect: "For this exercise, pick the one that shows up most under pressure. Not the one you aspire to. The one that shows up when you're stressed and don't have time to be strategic about it."

Signs This Is Working

Timeframe	What to Look For
During the session	Leaders identify genuine blind spots rather than performing self-awareness At least one leader says something that surprises themselves Peer-to-peer recognition: "I see that in you and it makes sense"
Within 2-4 weeks	A leader makes a deliberate vulnerability move with their team (shares uncertainty, asks for help, admits a mistake) A leader references their archetype in a subsequent conversation: "I'm doing my Stoic Strategist thing" Team members report (through CLOVER ERA or informally) that their leader felt more open or approachable
CLOVER ERA data (4-6 weeks)	Vulnerability scores increase for teams whose leaders participated Trust indicators improve Qualitative data from team members references leadership openness

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
V1: Vulnerability Circle	V4 gives leaders the self-awareness to model vulnerability. V1 gives them the forum to practise it with their team.	Run V4 before the leader facilitates V1
V5: Vulnerability Culture	V4 is the individual leader work. V5 is the organisational culture work. They complement each other.	Run V4 before V5
E6: Decision-Making Autonomy	The Perfectionist and Shield Bearer archetypes directly block autonomy. V4 awareness supports E6 implementation.	Complementary